Open-World Pixel MMORPG — Full Game Plan

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Vision and pitch

Build an original 2D pixel-art MMORPG for Android. It takes Inotia's dark-fantasy story and party feel and puts them in a Ragnarok-style shared world, where players trade, run vending stalls and form guilds. You earn from cosmetics, a season pass and convenience items. Players never cash out real money.

- **Working title:** *Shards of Velmora* (a placeholder; run a trademark search before launch)
- **Genre:** 2D top-down action MMORPG, pixel art, landscape mode
- **Audience:** players nostalgic for Inotia, Zenonia and Ragnarok Online, mostly on mid-range Android phones
- **Hook:** you can play solo thanks to hired mercenaries, but the best loot and the most fun come from parties, trading and guilds

IP rule: take nothing from Inotia (names, characters, maps, art, music, story) and nothing from Ragnarok (names, sprites, job names, card art). Mechanics such as job advancement, vending and socketed gear are free to use. Copied assets or names are not.

Mobile or web: both, from one codebase

Build the game with web technology and package it as an Android app. That gets you a Play Store app now and a browser version later from the same code, with no second client to maintain.

	Android app (Play Store)	Web game (browser)
Discovery	Play Store search, features, ratings	You have to bring all the traffic yourself
Payments	Google Play Billing; trusted and impulse-friendly, but Google takes a service fee	Stripe or PayPal; lower fees, but fewer impulse buys

	Android app (Play Store)	Web game (browser)
Updates	Client builds go through store review; server-side content updates go live instantly	Instant
Performance	Best	Good enough for 2D pixel art
Getting started	Players must download it	One link and they're playing
Push notifications	Yes	Limited

Recommendation: ship an Android app built with web tech (Phaser, wrapped with Capacitor). The Play Store gives you discovery and trusted payments, and those matter most for earnings. The web build then becomes free marketing: a playable link you can share on TikTok and in Facebook gaming groups. iOS can come later through the same Capacitor wrapper.

World, story and classes

Velmora is a continent that shattered when the Sunspire fell, leaving behind glowing Shards that grant power. Two forces fight over them. The Dawn Covenant wants to seal the Shards away; the Umbral Court wants to use them. The player is a Wayfarer, an outsider marked by a Shard and courted by both sides.

- **Main story:** a chapter-by-chapter questline (the Inotia feel). Each chapter unlocks a zone and ends in a boss dungeon.
- **Faction choice at level 30:** players join Dawn or Umbral, which unlocks faction quests, faction cosmetics and, later, faction-vs-faction zones.
- **Launch zones:** Harrowgate (the starter hub town and main market), Ashen Dunes, Whisperwood and Frostveil Peaks, plus 3 dungeons.

Class	Role	Job advancement at level 40
Vanguard	Tank: shields, taunts	Bulwark or Warlord
Shadowblade	Burst melee, stealth	Nightstalker or Duelist
Arcanist	Ranged magic, area damage	Pyromancer or Stormcaller
Warden	Bow plus light support	Ranger or Beastmaster

Class	Role	Job advancement at level 40
Hexer	Curses, damage over time, debuffs	Plaguecaller or Soulbinder
Cleric	Main healer, buffs, shields	Sanctifier or Oracle

All 6 classes are available at launch, giving every party a full spread of tanks, damage dealers and healers. Later updates add third-job advancements instead of new base classes, which brings veteran players back without splitting the playerbase.

Mercenaries: players hire NPC companions in towns, one at a time at launch. Mercenaries let solo players progress and keep the Inotia feel, but a real player party always beats them at bosses.

Core game systems

Launch with the systems that make players stay and trade, and leave everything else for updates.

Two layers: a private campaign and a shared open world (Albion-style)

	Story campaign	Open world
Who is there	Instanced: one player or their party	Everyone on the server
Purpose	Level up, learn your class, follow the story	Meet, trade, craft, fight bosses, guild wars, PvP
Rewards	EXP and account-bound gear (can't be traded)	Tradeable loot, crafting materials, rare sigils
Server cost	Low (small rooms, spun up on demand)	Higher (persistent zones, many players)

The rule that protects the economy: the campaign makes players strong, and the open world makes them rich. Tradeable items come mainly from open-world drops and player crafting, as in Albion, so the market always has demand.

At launch (v1)

- **Combat:** real-time, with a virtual joystick, auto-attack on tap and a 4-slot skill bar
- **Progression:** levels 1–60, stat points and a skill tree per class, job advancement at 40

- **Parties:** up to 4 players, with shared EXP and loot rules
- **Mercenaries:** one hired companion per player, upgradable
- **Loot and gear:**
  - rarity tiers
  - refining from +1 to +10, with a chance to fail
  - monster sigils socketed into gear (your own take on Ragnarok's cards)
- **Trading:** a face-to-face trade window with a two-step confirm, plus player vending stalls in Harrowgate
- **Chat:** zone, party, guild and whisper channels, with a profanity filter and a report button
- **Guilds:** create a guild, set ranks, guild chat, shared storage

Pets, mounts and battle mounts (at launch)

	Pets	Travel mounts	Battle mounts
What it does	Follows you, auto-picks up loot, gives a small passive bonus	Faster movement outside combat	Ridden in combat, with its own skills (charge, trample, roar)
How you get one	Tame wild monsters with a taming item; also hatch eggs	Campaign quest at level 20, crafting, rare open-world drops	Open-world bosses, guild content and crafting, from level 45
Progression	Feed it to raise loyalty; it levels up and unlocks bonuses	Different speeds by tier	Levels up, with gear slots (saddle, armor)
Tradeable?	Yes, as eggs or tamed pets: a big part of the market	Crafted mounts yes, quest mounts no	Yes, which makes them top-tier trade goods
In the shop	Skins only	Skins only	Skins only

- Battle mount stats stay below gear in power, and heavy hits knock the rider off. That keeps PvP about skill, not whoever owns the best mount.
- Pets support you and mercenaries fight for you, so a solo player can run with both.
- The server's movement-speed checks must account for each mount's speed, or legitimate riders will be flagged as speed hackers.

After launch

- Auction house (search listings and buy from anyone, even when the seller is offline)
- Guild halls and weekly guild-vs-guild battles
- Opt-in faction PvP zones
- World bosses on a timer
- Crafting professions and player housing
- Seasonal events

Traded items only hold value if they stay scarce. So every item gets a unique ID, and every trade is logged.

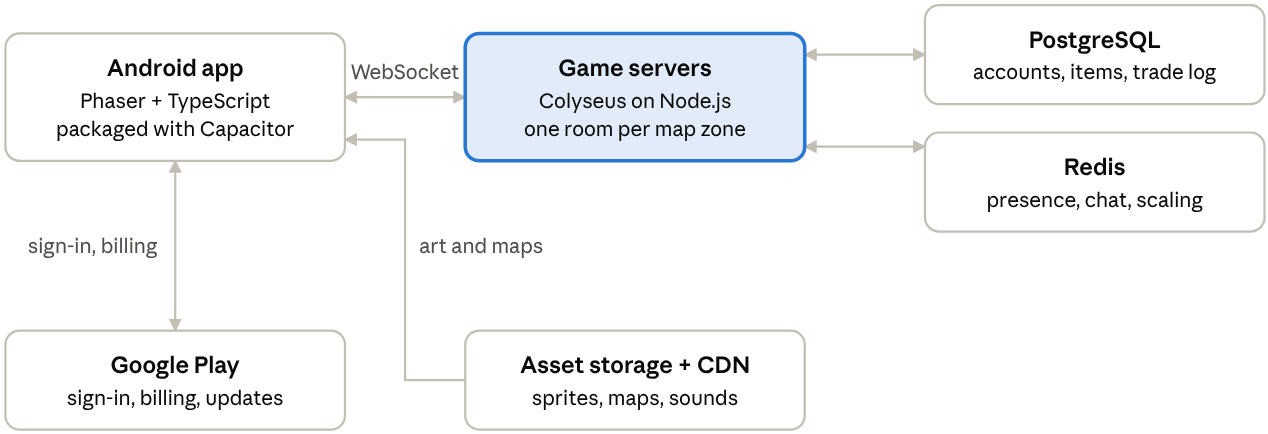
Tech stack

Use TypeScript end to end, on both the client and the server. One language suits your software and cloud background, and it lets you share code (item stats, damage formulas) between client and server.

Layer	Choice	Why
Game client	Phaser 3 + TypeScript	Mature 2D web engine, good for pixel art
Android packaging	Capacitor	Wraps the web build as a Play Store app; iOS later with the same tool
Maps	Tiled editor	Standard tilemap tool that loads straight into Phaser
Game server	Colyseus (Node.js)	Rooms per zone and per campaign instance, state synced to players
Database	PostgreSQL	Accounts, characters, inventories, trade log; transactions keep trades safe
Cache and messaging	Redis	Who is online, chat, messages between server instances
Login	Google Play Games sign-in or Firebase Auth	Free, one-tap login on Android

Layer	Choice	Why
Payments	Google Play Billing	Receipts are verified on your server before items are granted
Analytics and crashes	Firebase Analytics + Crashlytics	Free; shows where players quit
Art	Aseprite + itch.io asset packs	Prototype with packs, replace with original art later

Players talk only to the game servers, which own all the data



system architecture · 6 parts

The server is authoritative: the app only sends inputs (move, attack, use skill), and the server decides damage, drops and trades. Purchases are checked with Google Play from the server side.

Alternative: if you'd rather work in a full game engine, Godot 4 for the client plus Nakama for the backend is the other solid route. You'd lose the shared language but gain a visual editor.

Hosting and infrastructure

Start on one cheap server and move to containers once you have real players. Host near your players: Singapore for Southeast Asia, Frankfurt for Europe and the Middle East. Once ping goes above roughly 150 ms, real-time combat starts to feel laggy.

Stage	Setup	Approx. monthly cost
Development	Docker Compose on your machine: game server, Postgres, Redis	$0
Closed alpha (up to ~100 players)	1 VPS (4 vCPU, 8 GB RAM) running everything in Docker Compose; daily database backups to object storage	$20–50
Open beta (up to ~1,000 online at once)	2–3 game server VMs behind a load balancer, managed Postgres, managed Redis, CDN for assets	$150–400
Launch and growth	Game servers autoscaled on Kubernetes, database read replicas, CDN	$500+ and rising with players

Providers: Hetzner is the cheapest for VPS. DigitalOcean is simple and has managed databases. AWS or GCP fit if you want everything managed. All costs above are rough estimates.

Ops checklist

- CI/CD with GitHub Actions: build the server Docker image and the Android app bundle (AAB) on every push
- A separate staging environment, never testing on production
- Monitoring with Prometheus + Grafana, plus uptime alerts to your phone
- Daily backups, with a restore you've actually tested
- Zero-downtime deploys: stop new players joining old rooms, let them empty, then restart

Monetization

Earn from cosmetics, a season pass and convenience, and never sell raw power. Paid power ruins the player economy that trading depends on.

Product	What it is	Approx. price
Cosmetics	Outfits, weapon skins, mounts (visual only)	$1.99–9.99
Season pass	Free and premium reward tracks, about 8 weeks each	$4.99
Premium membership	Extra storage, an extra vending slot, a small EXP bonus	$4.99 / month
Convenience	Extra character slots, name change, bigger bags	$0.99–4.99
Gem bundles	Premium currency used in the shop	$0.99–49.99
Rewarded ads (optional)	Watch an ad for a short buff	Ad revenue from non-payers

- In-app purchases on Android must go through Google Play Billing. Google takes a service fee, currently 15% on the first $1M of earnings each year for most developers; confirm the current rate in Play Console.
- Avoid paid random loot boxes at launch. Google requires you to publish the odds, and many countries are tightening the rules on them.
- Fees charged in gold (the in-game currency), such as vending tax or auction fees, are not revenue. They exist to remove gold from the game and keep prices stable.
- Typically only 2–5% of players ever pay, so the free experience has to be good on its own.

Economy safety, anti-cheat and legal

A single item-duplication bug or bot farm can wreck the economy in a weekend, so build these protections in from day one.

Economy

- The server decides everything: the app never reports damage, gold or loot
- Each trade runs as one database transaction: lock both sides' items in escrow, then swap, or roll back completely
- Every item has a unique ID, and an append-only log records every trade, drop and purchase

- Gold sinks keep prices stable: repair costs, refining fees, vending tax, teleport fees
- An economy dashboard tracks total gold in circulation and gold earned per player per hour

Anti-cheat and bots

- Rate limits on actions and chat; the server checks movement speed and position
- Flag non-human play, such as round-the-clock farming or identical paths
- Google Play Integrity API to block modified apps
- Ban in waves, not instantly, so cheaters can't tell what triggered detection

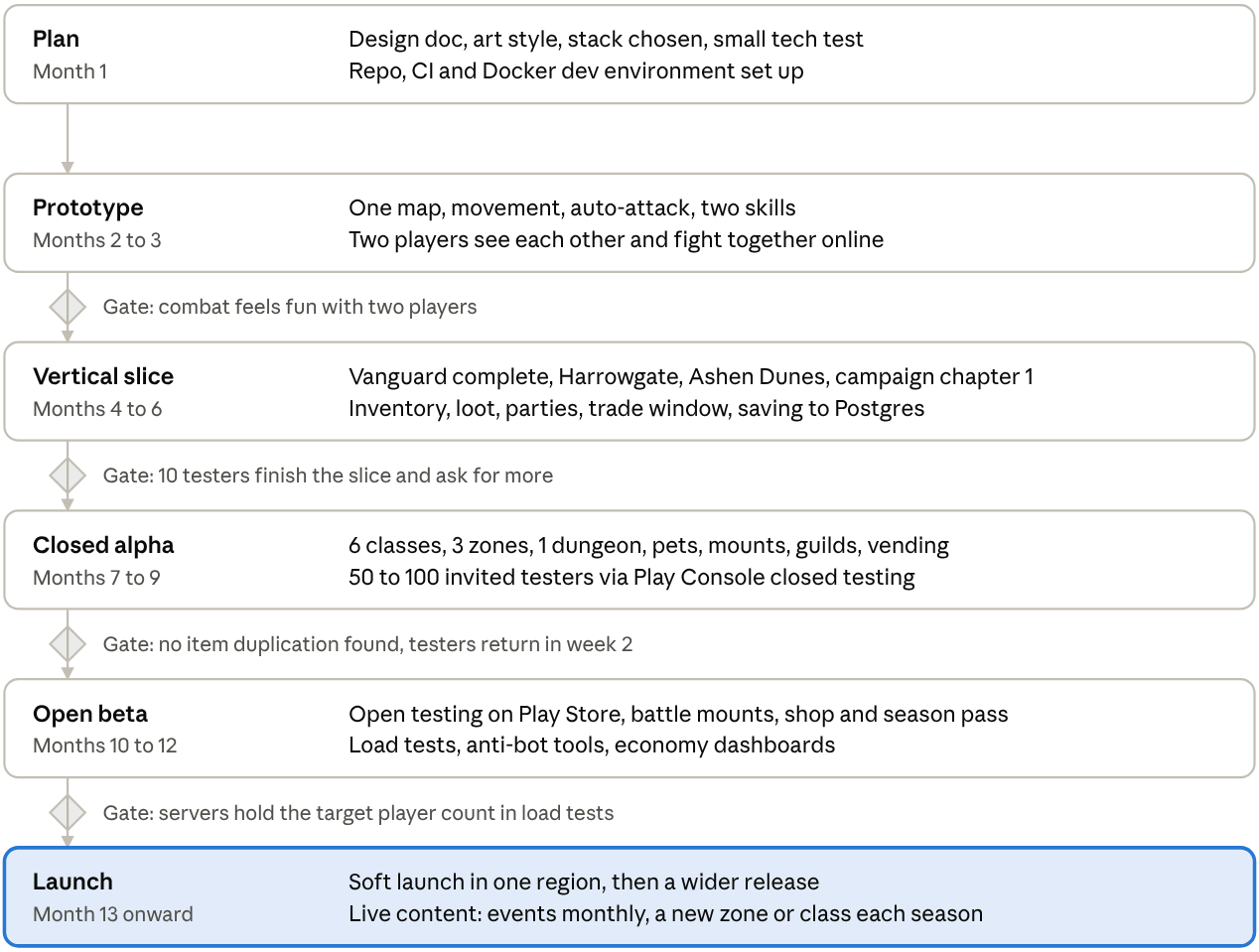
Legal

- Terms of service that ban real-money trading of accounts and items
- A privacy policy, plus the Data safety form in Play Console
- An age rating through the IARC questionnaire in Play Console
- Original names and art only, plus a trademark search on the final title
- Decide whether to publish as an individual or a company, and check Google Play's merchant requirements for the UAE; a local business advisor can confirm the licensing side

Roadmap

Aim for a first playable build by month 3 and launch around month 13, assuming you work with one part-time artist. Expect it to take longer: each gate is a checkpoint where you fix problems before adding more content.

First playable by month 3, launch around month 13



roadmap · 6 phases, 4 gates

Don't move past a gate until it's met. Fun combat and a safe economy matter more than the number of zones.

Team, budget and next steps

The smallest team that can ship this is you plus one part-time freelance pixel artist. You'd handle the server, backend and client code. Music and sound effects can come from licensed packs at first.

Item	Approx. cost, first 12 months
Pixel art (freelancer)	$3,000–10,000, or $200–500 in asset packs to start

Item	Approx. cost, first 12 months
Music and sound effects	$100–1,000 (licensed packs)
Hosting through open beta	$500–1,500
Google Play developer account	$25, one time
Tools, domain, misc.	About $100
Total	**Roughly $4,000–13,000**

This week

- [ ] Pick the final working title and run a quick trademark search
- [ ] Write a 2-page design doc covering the classes, zones, campaign vs open world, and the core loop
- [ ] Set up the repo: a Phaser + Colyseus starter, plus Docker Compose with Postgres and Redis
- [ ] Tech test: two browser tabs moving around one shared tilemap
- [ ] Buy a pixel-art asset pack to prototype with
- [ ] Register the Google Play developer account

Biggest risk: scope. Cut features before you cut quality. A small world that feels alive beats a huge empty one.